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DANIEL WILCO | NCAA.COM | FEBRUARY 9, 2026

What is March Madness: The NCAA tournament explained

DI MEN'S BASKETBALL

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March Madness is one of the most anticipated and watched events in all of sports. Here's everything you need to know about the NCAA Division I men's basketball tournament, which has been played since 1939.

What is March Madness?

The NCAA Division I men's basketball tournament is a single-elimination tournament of 68 teams that compete in seven rounds for the national championship. The penultimate round is known as the Final Four, when (you guessed it) only four teams are left.

What (and when) is Selection Sunday?

Selection Sunday is the day when the Selection Committee reveals the full NCAA tournament bracket, including all teams and all seeds. We update this article every year with information on when Selection Sunday is and how to watch the bracket reveal.

When is this year's March Madness men's tournament?

Here is the full schedule for this season's 2026 NCAA men's basketball tournament.

- Selection Sunday: Sunday, March 15
- First Four: March 17-18
- First round: March 19-20
- Second round: March 21-22
- Sweet 16: March 26-27
- Elite Eight: March 28-39
- Final Four: April 4 at Lucas Oil Stadium in Indianapolis
- NCAA championship game: April 6 at Lucas Oil Stadium in Indianapolis

Where can I get an NCAA bracket?

You can click or tap here to get a printable .PDF of the NCAA bracket. It will open in a new tab or window. You can also go here to see the official interactive bracket.

When did March Madness start?

The first NCAA Division I men's basketball tournament was in 1939 and was held every year until the 2019-20 season. The event was canceled in 2020 because of the coronavirus pandemic.

The inaugural tournament had just eight teams, and saw Oregon beat Ohio State 46-33 for the title.

In 1951, the field doubled to 16, and kept expanding over the next few decades until 1985, when the modern format of a 64-team tournament began. In 2001, after the Mountain West Conference joined Division I and received an automatic bid, pushing the total teams to 65, a single game was added prior to the first round. In 2011, three more teams were added, and with them, three more games to round out the First Four.

Where did the term “March Madness” come from?

March Madness was first used to refer to basketball by an Illinois high school official, Henry V. Porter, in 1939, but the term didn’t find its way to the NCAA tournament until CBS broadcaster Brent Musburger (who used to be a sportswriter in Chicago) used it during coverage of the 1982 tournament. The term has been synonymous with the NCAA Division I men’s basketball tournament ever since.

How are the teams selected?

There are two ways that a team can earn a bid to the NCAA tournament. The 31 Division I conferences all receive an automatic bid, which they each award to the team that wins the postseason conference

teams are known as automatic qualifiers.

The second avenue for an invitation is an at-large bid. The selection committee (more on them in a second) convenes on Selection Sunday, after all regular season and conference tournament games are played, and decides which 37 teams that are not automatic qualifiers have the pedigree to earn an invitation to the tournament.

What is the March Madness selection committee?

The NCAA Men's Division I Basketball Committee is responsible for selecting, seeding and bracketing the field for the NCAA tournament. School and conference administrators are nominated by their conference, serve five-year terms and represent a cross-section of the Division I membership.

How do they decide which teams get an at-large bid?

There are a multitude of stats and rankings that the Selection Committee takes into account, but there is no set formula that determines whether a team receives an at-large bid or not.

What happens once the teams are selected?

Once the field of 68 is finalized, each team is assigned a seed and placed in one of four regions, which determines their first round matchups and their path to the championship.

What are seeds?

The NCAA men’s basketball tournament is made up of 68 teams. On Selection Sunday, before any tournament game is played, those teams are ranked 1 through 68 by the Selection Committee, with the best team in college basketball — based on regular season and conference tournament performance — sitting at No. 1. Four of those teams are eliminated in the opening round of the tournament (known as the First Four), leaving us with a field of 64 for the first round.

Those 64 teams are split into four regions of 16 teams each, with each team being ranked 1 through 16. That ranking is the team’s seed.

In order to reward better teams, first-round matchups are determined by pitting the top team in the region against the bottom team (No. 1 vs. No. 16). Then the next highest vs. the next lowest (No. 2 vs. No.

How to watch March Madness:

Every March Madness game will be broadcast on either TBS, TNT, TruTV or CBS. You can also stream every game on March Madness Live.

How can you participate in March Madness?

By filling out a bracket! The Bracket Challenge Game, the official bracket game of the NCAA, will open immediately after the committee announces the field on Selection Sunday. The brackets will lock before the first game of the first round begins, so get your picks in before then. How hard is filling out a bracket? Well no one has ever gotten a perfect bracket, but that shouldn't stop you from trying.

What are the odds of a perfect bracket?

- About 1 in 9,223,372,036,854,775,808 (if you just guess or flip a coin)
- Roughly 1 in 120.2 billion (if you know a little something about basketball, like not picking all 16 seeds to make the Final Four)

You can see how we arrived at those numbers in this article, first written in 2018 by NCAA.com's Daniel Wilco.

Who has won every NCAA tournament?

Since the tournament's inception, no team has won more than UCLA, which has 11 — 10 of which came a span of 12 years from 1964 to 1975.

YEAR	CHAMPION (RECORD)	COACH	SCORE	RUNNER-UP
2025	Florida (36-4)	Todd Golden	65-63	Houston
2024	UConn (37-3)	Dan Hurley	75-60	Purdue
2023	Connecticut (31-8)	Dan Hurley	76-59	San Diego State
2022	Kansas (34-6)	Bill Self	72-69	North Carolina
2021	Baylor (28-2)	Scott Drew	86-70	Gonzaga
2020	Canceled due to COVID-19	--	--	--
2019	Virginia (35-3)	Tony Bennett	85-77 (OT)	Texas Tech
2018	Villanova (36-4)	Jay Wright	79-62	Michigan
2017	North Carolina (33-7)	Roy Williams	71-65	Gonzaga
2016	Villanova (35-5)	Jay Wright	77-74	North Carolina
2015	Duke (35-4)	Mike Krzyzewski	68-63	Wisconsin
2014	Connecticut (32-8)	Kevin Ollie	60-54	Kentucky
2013	Louisville (35-5)*	Rick Pitino	82-76	Michigan
2012	Kentucky (38-2)	John Calipari	67-59	Kansas
2011	Connecticut (32-9)	Jim Calhoun	53-41	Butler
2010	Duke (35-5)	Mike Krzyzewski	61-59	Butler
2009	North Carolina (34-4)	Roy Williams	89-72	Michigan State
2008	Kansas (37-3)	Bill Self	75-68 (OT)	Memphis
2007	Florida (35-5)	Billy Donovan	84-75	Ohio State
2006	Florida (33-6)	Billy Donovan	73-57	UCLA
2005	North Carolina (33-4)	Roy Williams	75-70	Illinois
2004	Connecticut (33-6)	Jim Calhoun	82-73	Georgia Tech
2003	Syracuse (30-5)	Jim Boeheim	81-78	Kansas
2002	Maryland (32-4)	Gary Williams	64-52	Indiana
2001	Duke (35-4)	Mike Krzyzewski	82-72	Arizona
2000	Michigan State (32-7)	Tom Izzo	89-76	Florida

1999	Connecticut (34-2)	Jim Calhoun	77-74	Duke
1998	Kentucky (35-4)	Tubby Smith	78-69	Utah
1997	Arizona (25-9)	Lute Olson	84-79 (OT)	Kentucky
1996	Kentucky (34-2)	Rick Pitino	76-67	Syracuse
1995	UCLA (31-2)	Jim Harrick	89-78	Arkansas
1994	Arkansas (31-3)	Nolan Richardson	76-72	Duke
1993	North Carolina (34-4)	Dean Smith	77-71	Michigan
1992	Duke (34-2)	Mike Krzyzewski	71-51	Michigan
1991	Duke (32-7)	Mike Krzyzewski	72-65	Kansas
1990	UNLV (35-5)	Jerry Tarkanian	103-73	Duke
1989	Michigan (30-7)	Steve Fisher	80-79 (OT)	Seton Hall
1988	Kansas (27-11)	Larry Brown	83-79	Oklahoma
1987	Indiana (30-4)	Bob Knight	74-73	Syracuse
1986	Louisville (32-7)	Denny Crum	72-69	Duke
1985	Villanova (25-10)	Rollie Massimino	66-64	Georgetown
1984	Georgetown (34-3)	John Thompson	84-75	Houston
1983	North Carolina State (26-10)	Jim Valvano	54-52	Houston
1982	North Carolina (32-2)	Dean Smith	63-62	Georgetown
1981	Indiana (26-9)	Bob Knight	63-50	North Carolina
1980	Louisville (33-3)	Denny Crum	59-54	UCLA
1979	Michigan State (26-6)	Jud Heathcote	75-64	Indiana State
1978	Kentucky (30-2)	Joe Hall	94-88	Duke
1977	Marquette (25-7)	Al McGuire	67-59	North Carolina
1976	Indiana (32-0)	Bob Knight	86-68	Michigan
1975	UCLA (28-3)	John Wooden	92-85	Kentucky
1974	North Carolina State (30-1)	Norm Sloan	76-64	Marquette
1973	UCLA (30-0)	John Wooden	87-66	Memphis State
1972	UCLA (30-0)	John Wooden	81-76	Florida State

1971	UCLA (29-1)	John Wooden	68-62	Villanova
1970	UCLA (28-2)	John Wooden	80-69	Jacksonville
1969	UCLA (29-1)	John Wooden	92-72	Purdue
1968	UCLA (29-1)	John Wooden	78-55	North Carolina
1967	UCLA (30-0)	John Wooden	79-64	Dayton
1966	UTEP (28-1)	Don Haskins	72-65	Kentucky
1965	UCLA (28-2)	John Wooden	91-80	Michigan
1964	UCLA (30-0)	John Wooden	98-83	Duke
1963	Loyola (Ill.) (29-2)	George Ireland	60-58 (OT)	Cincinnati
1962	Cincinnati (29-2)	Ed Jucker	71-59	Ohio State
1961	Cincinnati (27-3)	Ed Jucker	70-65 (OT)	Ohio State
1960	Ohio State (25-3)	Fred Taylor	75-55	California
1959	California (25-4)	Pete Newell	71-70	West Virginia
1958	Kentucky (23-6)	Adolph Rupp	84-72	Seattle
1957	North Carolina (32-0)	Frank McGuire	54-53 (3OT)	Kansas
1956	San Francisco (29-0)	Phil Woolpert	83-71	Iowa
1955	San Francisco (28-1)	Phil Woolpert	77-63	LaSalle
1954	La Salle (26-4)	Ken Loeffler	92-76	Bradley
1953	Indiana (23-3)	Branch McCracken	69-68	Kansas
1952	Kansas (28-3)	Phog Allen	80-63	St. John's
1951	Kentucky (32-2)	Adolph Rupp	68-58	Kansas State
1950	CCNY (24-5)	Nat Holman	71-68	Bradley
1949	Kentucky (32-2)	Adolph Rupp	46-36	Oklahoma A&M
1948	Kentucky (36-3)	Adolph Rupp	58-42	Baylor
1947	Holy Cross (27-3)	Doggie Julian	58-47	Oklahoma
1946	Oklahoma State (31-2)	Henry Iba	43-40	North Carolina
1945	Oklahoma State (27-4)	Henry Iba	49-45	NYU
1944	Utah (21-4)	Vadal Peterson	42-40 (OT)	Dartmouth

1943	Wyoming (31-2)	Everett Shelton	46-34	Georgetown
1942	Stanford (28-4)	Everett Dean	53-38	Dartmouth
1941	Wisconsin (20-3)	Bud Foster	39-34	Washington State
1940	Indiana (20-3)	Branch McCracken	60-42	Kansas
1939	Oregon (29-5)	Howard Hobson	46-33	Ohio State

**Louisville's participation in the 2013 tournament was later vacated by the Committee on Infractions.*

March Madness glossary:

The Madness of March isn't just confined to what happens on the basketball court. When discussing teams, there are a bevy of statistics, terms, and acronyms thrown out. There's a team's NET rankings and BPI. The SOS and the SOR. The automatic bid and the at-large bid. It can be a bit daunting.

Maybe you've never heard of any of these, maybe you just need a quick refresher. Either way, we've compiled a list of the 29 most helpful terms when dealing with the NCAA tournament. These are stats and phrases that the Selection Committee will use to determine the field, and understanding what they mean can go a long way in helping you make informed decisions while filling out your bracket.

At-large bid — Teams that receive a bid to the NCAA tournament are broken into two categories: At-large bids, and automatic bids. The selection committee hands out 37 at-large bids to teams that did not win their conference tournament, but impressed the committee enough to earn a trip to the tournament. There is no limit on the number of at-large teams the committee may select from one conference.

Automatic bid — In Division I, there are 31 conferences. Each has its own conference tournament at the conclusion of the regular season. Teams that win this tournament, regardless of their regular-season performance, automatically earn a trip to the NCAA tournament.

AP ranking – The Associated Press has been ranking the top basketball teams since 1948. In its current form, the poll ranks the top 25 teams in Division I via a ranking that is compiled from the ballots of 65 sports journalists across the country. The ranking has no official weight in the selection process, and even a No. 1 ranking in the AP poll does not technically guarantee a team a bid to the NCAA tournament. View the current AP rankings here.

BPI — College Basketball's Power Index, invented by ESPN, is a statistic that measures how far above or below average every team is, and projects how well the team will do going forward. The index uses two measurements to do this: BPI Offense (measure of a team's offensive strength compared to an average offense) and BPI Defense (measure of a team's defensive strength compared to an average defense). BPI is

The bubble — A team that is “on the bubble” for the NCAA tournament is one whose qualification for the tournament could go either way. They’re on the verge of making the field of 68, but an invitation isn’t guaranteed.

Cinderella — Much like the titular character from the fairy tale, a Cinderella team is one that is much more successful than expected. Examples in March would be Villanova’s 1985 championship run, when the eighth-seeded Wildcats became the lowest seeded team to ever win the title, knocking off the heavy favorite Georgetown.

Defensive efficiency — A simple statistic that calculates the points allowed per 100 defensive possessions. For example, if Team A’s opponent scored 80 points in a game with 75 possessions, Team A’s defensive efficiency would be 106.7. View current defensive efficiency rankings here.

Elite Eight — The fourth round of the tournament, when just eight teams remain, is known as the Elite Eight. This round is the final game for each regional, before the four winners move on to the national semifinal, known as the Final Four.

Final Four — The fifth round of the tournament, when just four teams remain, is known as the Final Four. This is the penultimate round of the tournament, when the winners of each regional face off for a chance to play in the championship game.

First Four — When the NCAA tournament was expanded to 68 teams, a new round was added to the format: The First Four. Four games, played on the Tuesday and Wednesday after Selection Sunday, determine which of eight teams advance to the first round of the tournament.

First four out — When ranking all 68 teams in the NCAA tournament, the First Four Out fall in spots 69-72. These teams will not make the NCAA tournament, but will be the top-seeded teams in the NIT Championship.

Last four in — Another unofficial term, the "last four in" refers to the final four teams that receive at-large bids to the tournament. These are teams that are usually on the bubble as Selection Sunday draws near.

NET — NCAA Evaluation Tool was a new ranking in 2018-19 that relies on game results, strength of schedule, game location, scoring margin, net offensive and defensive efficiency, and the quality of wins and losses. The ranking replaces RPI as the main sorting tool for the selection committee. Some of the unique aspects of the NET include the omission of game date and order (to give equal importance to both early and late-season games), and the inclusion of a cap of 10 points for winning margin (to prevent teams needlessly running up the score in a game where the outcome was certain).

efficiency rankings here.

Pace/Tempo — An estimate of the number of possessions a team has per regulation (40 minutes).

Per-40 stats — A reference used to compare two or more players who do not play the same amount of minutes per game. It is measured by taking each statistic, dividing it by the minutes played per game, and then multiplying it by 40 — a full regulation game. For example, if Player A scores an average of 20 points in 30 minutes of play, his points per-40 would be 26.7.

POM — Kenpom.com, run by Ken Pomeroy, is a website devoted to advanced basketball statistics. The site gives an overall rating to each Division I team throughout the season based on a multitude of advanced metrics. The Selection Committee uses these rankings to help evaluate teams.

Quadrants (Q1, Q2, Q3, Q4) — In order to determine the strength of a team's wins or losses, the selection committee divides the team's record into four quadrants on each team sheet. The quadrants are meant to serve as an indicator of how good a team's wins are, or how bad their losses are. Each quadrant is divided based on a combination of the location of the game — Home (H), Neutral court (N), or Away (A) — and the opponent's NET ranking.

- **Q1:** H: 1-30; N: 1-50; A: 1-75
- **Q2:** H: 31-75; N: 51-100; A: 76-135
- **Q3:** H: 76-160; N: 101-200; A: 136-240
- **Q4:** H:161-353; N: 201-353; A: 241-353

Regional — The NCAA tournament bracket is split into four regionals. The South, East, West, and Midwest. The first four rounds of the tournament are played in regionals, with the Elite Eight serving as the regional championship game. Teams are assigned a regional based on a combination of factors, such as overall seed, proximity to the regional, the other teams in that regional, and more.

Seed — 68 teams earn bids to the NCAA tournament, and each one receives a seed — from 1 to 16 —that determines where the team will be placed in the bracket. After the First Four, there are four of every seed. The seeds are also ranked overall from 1 to 68. This overall ranking affects the order in which team locations are selected (with higher-ranked teams getting preference), and which teams play in the First Four (the four lowest-seeded at-large teams and the four lowest-seeded automatic qualifiers go to the First Four).

Selection committee —The NCAA Men's Division I Basketball Committee is responsible for selecting, seeding and bracketing the field for the NCAA Tournament. School and conference administrators are nominated by their conference, serve five-year terms and represent a cross-section of the Division I membership.

Strength of record — From ESPN: "Strength of Record (SOR) is a measure of team accomplishment based on how difficult a team's W-L record is to achieve. SOR reflects the chance a typical 25th ranked team would have team's record or better, given the schedule on a 0 to 100 scale, where 100 is best."

Strength of schedule — Strength of Schedule (or SoS) measures the difficulty of a team's schedule, based on the win percentage of the team's opponents.

Sweet 16 — The third round of the tournament, where only 16 teams remain. The winner of each game will play in the Elite Eight.

Team sheet — A one-page document for every team in Division I that helps the committee get a complete picture of that team's performance during the season. The team sheets contain in-depth team information about strength of schedule, performance against top-50 teams and home/road records.

Daniel Wilco has worked at the AJC, Sports Illustrated, and SEC Country. His writing has also appeared on SI.com, Men's Health, and The Cauldron.

The views on this page do not necessarily reflect the views of the NCAA or its member institutions.

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5 NCAA bracket tips learned from studying every Bracket Challenge Game winner since 2015

We looked at every winning NCAA bracket since 2015 to find what it was that helped the likes of mjbrewer and KELSEY 2017 beat out millions of other March Madness prognosticators.

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